Bonsey

By Charlayne Woodard

CHARLAYNE: When I was ten years old, I loved . . . a secret. I'd give my eyetooth for anyone to share a secret with me. And kids did! Oh yes. They'd tell me their secrets, and I wouldn't tell a soul. To this day, I have those secrets locked up in my heart. But *I* had secrets I never told. Secrets I never shared with . . . *(she finds an audience member)* anyone. *(Pause.)*

INTRODUCTION

There are safe secrets: A surprise birthday party, Christmas gifts, and what boy your best friend has a crush on. And there are unsafe secrets. The kind Charlayne Woodward keeps is an unsafe secret: as secret of assault, harassment and abuse. Bonsey by Charlayne Woodard.

CHARLAYNE: Let's share some secrets this evening . . . I'll go first. When I was ten years old, my aunt Carolyn moved up from Savannah to live with us, while she went to nursing school. Every day when Allie and I came home from our schools, my aunt Carolyn would call us into her room.

CAROLYN: *(Primping in the mirror;)* "Charlayne, Allie! *(As she waits for her nieces, she sings to "Shotgun" by junior Walker and the All Stars and does the Soulfinger. The girls interrupt her.)* Do me a favor and run up to Bernie's corner store. Get me a block of Philadelphia cream cheese and a bag of onion and garlic potato chips. Here, honey. *(She takes a dollar from her bosom.)* Hurry back before your momma and your daddy get home."

CHARLAYNE: Now, in order to get to Bernie's corner store, Allie and I had to walk

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up Second Street, past School 6, past some neat little houses that looked a lot like ours. . . . It was a nice walk . . . until we reached that last house just before the corner. This house was right out of a horror movie. If it wasn't condemned, it should've been. This is where Robert Blair lived . . . . Robert Blair. And his seven, rude, lowlife, snot-dribbling-out-of-their-noses, bound-for-the-detention-center brothers. If they had parents, nobody knew. We never saw them. Just those Blair boys, out on their stoop, all hours of the day and night, shooting spitballs, cursing, smoking cigarettes . . . .

Allie and I would start up Second Street . . . holding hands. *(She walks across the stage.)* We had our heads bowed to the ground. We were trying to be invisible. "Ssssh! Stop breathing, Allie. They might hear us!"

(Looking up;) Too late. Robert Blair spotted us before we even got near his house. He'd come slithering across his old front yard *(becoming Robert Blair, walking with an obvious "pimp, " smoking)*, had a cigarette dangling out the side of his mouth, lean up against his old, raggedy fence.

ROBERT: *(Menacing.)* "Bonesy! Hey, Bonesy! When you and your liver-lipped sister gonna give me some?"

CHARLAYNE: And as if that wasn't bad enough, he'd sic his dog, Sooner, on us.

ROBERT: "Sick 'em, Sooner! Sic 'em!"

CHARLAYNE: Now, Sooner was the dog from hell. He had one white, blind eye, with a whole lot of white stuff dribbling out of that. Then he had one black eye, that just came at you, like daggers.

Old Sooner'd come tearing down that front stoop. I'd grab Allie's hand and we'd jump up on the nearest parked car. *(She runs and jumps.)* "No, Sooner! No, boy! Please, Sooner! Down! Down, boy! Down! No!

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Stay, Sooner! Stay. Good boy . . . . " *(climbs down from car and back pedals while watching the dog until they get to the Bernie's – enters the door still back-pedaling, then heaves a sign of relief and turns)*

Hi, Bernie. A block of Philadelphia cream cheese and a bag of onion and garlic potato chips, please."

Bernie would pass us the food over the counter, in a brown paper bag, and hand us our change.

Now we had to get home . . . . Allie and I would look each other dead in the eye . . .

"Get on your mark, get set, go!"

And we'd tear out of Bernie's, running down Second Street, as fast as we could, but as soon as we passed Robert Blair's house, he'd sic that dog on us *(running in a large circle)*, and old Sooner would be right on our heels, right on our heels . . . And not until we got past School 6 did Robert Blair call his mangy dog back home. *(She stops running.)*

Every single school day, we risked our lives for a block of Philadelphia cream cheese and a bag of onion and garlic potato chips.

Oh, but then came Saturday. We loved Saturday, because Saturday meant no going to school, no going to Sunday school, even. And no going to Bernie's! Because my aunt didn't dare send us on errands when my parents were at home.

On Saturday, when we woke up, my mother would be preparing the "breakfast of life." You know what that is: grits, with butter; scrambled eggs with onions; fresh-baked biscuits with her own homemade preserves spread all over those; fresh-squeezed orange juice. . . . Ooooh! The "breakfast of life"!

Mommy came into the living room and said,

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MOTHER: "Charlayne, we've run out of grits. Run up to Bernie's corner store and get me a box."

CHARLAYNE: *(Pause.)* I looked around and Allie had totally disappeared.

Then my mother said,

MOTHER: "Charlayne, it's raining out. You can wear your new rain slicker."

CHARLAYNE: My new yellow rain slicker! I got dressed in a flash, and Mommy took that rain slicker out of the closet. I put it on. You could still smell the rubber! It had this really *keen* hood that would just grip your face. *(She demonstrates with her hands.)* You couldn't see from side to side. And then it had this really *keen* beak that came down like this, so when the rain hit, the water would just slide off your head! Whoosh!

There were these really great puddles left over from last night's downpour. *(She jumps from puddle to puddle.)*

Made it to Bernie's.

"Good morning, Bernie. Look at me! Can I have a box of grits, please? *(Listens to Bernie.)* A licorice?! Sure. Thanks, Bernie . . . Oh, Bernie, can I have one for Allie, please . . . ? Thank you, Bernie."

Bernie passed me the grits in a brown paper bag, and he gave me my change.

When I looked outside, it was pouring rain. I couldn't wait to get out in it. *(Singing and dancing a la Gene Kelly.) (She freezes.)*

Robert Blair. I couldn't see him. But I could feel him right in back of me. So I started walking really fast. He came right up beside me. He was so close he was touching my arm. I couldn't see him, though, because of my keen hood.

ROBERT: "Hey, Bonesy . . . when you gonna give me some?"

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CHARLAYNE: *(Puzzled;)* And I'm thinking . . . "Gimme some *what?*" Then I just took off, running . . . But Robert Blair was one of those big boys. And he was doing what big boys do. He ran in front of me, backpedaling, blocking me. . . . I couldn't get around him. When I tried . . . he grabbed me, he pushed me up, up, up onto School 6's steps, up against the iron gates that locked the school. He snatched my hood down off my head. He wrapped his arm around that iron bar in back of my head and grabbed my hair. He took his other hand and he held me at my throat.

No one was out in that rain that day. No one in the whole world, but me . . . and Robert Blair.

He was pressing up against me. He was breathing on me.

"Let me go, Robert Blair. Please?"

He knocked the grits out of my arm, onto the stone steps. And still pressing up against me, he took his hand and put it . . . up under my rain slicker, and he placed it . . . in between my legs. *(Pause.)*

"Please let me go, Robert Blair."

ROBERT: "What do you call this . . . Bonesy?"

CHARLAYNE: "I don't know what you call it. I don't call it anything. Honest."

And then he *squeezed* me down there, really hard.

ROBERT: "You got to call it something, Bonesy! I said what do you call it?"

CHARLAYNE: *(In pain, frightened.)* "I don't know what you call it, Robert Blair. Honest to God. I don't call it anything."

ROBERT: *(Banging her head into the iron bars for emphasis as he speaks.)* "What . . . do . . . you . . . call . . . this, Bonesy?"

CHARLAYNE: *(Searching desperately for an answer.)* "Okay . . . okay . . . okay . . . my mother's a nurse . . . she calls it something. *(He squeezes her down there.)*

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My mother calls it . . . it's . . . Okay . . . ! Okay . . . ! It's . . . . a ragina?"

ROBERT: "A what?"

CHARLAYNE: *(Yelling desperately.)* "It's a ragina!"

ROBERT: "What the hell is a 'ragina,' Bonesy? Don't give me any of your big words! *(He squeezes her.)* I said *(banging her head again),* what do you call this?!"

CHARLAYNE: "Okay . . . okay . . . wait . . . wait . . . *(Still searching desperately.)* It's a . . . it's . . . it's . . . *(humiliated)* a pee-pee hole?"

Well, the light came to Robert Blair's face. I watched him throw back his head, and fall back into that rain. Just like some horrible bird, Robert Blair *flew* all the way up Second Street. Laughing at me! *(She notices what's left of the grits on the stone steps. Defeated, she kneels and attempts to gather as much as she can, and puts it back into the soaked box. Painfully, she stands and walks to her house. She's about to knock on the door, when she stops and decides to wipe away her tears. She pulls her "keen" hood back on her head, then . . . she knocks on the door.)* "I'm sorry, Mommy. I dropped the grits."

MOTHER: "Would you look at you. You certainly did get caught in that downpour. Oh, it's okay, Charlayne. It's just a box of grits. Give me this mess." *(Mother takes the wet, tattered box and throws it out.)*

CHARLAYNE: Then Mommy went into her bedroom and she came back with a dollar and an umbrella.

MOTHER: "Here. Run back to Bernie's and get me another box. Hurry now. Breakfast is waiting."

CHARLAYNE: And I just lost my legs and fell to the rug. I couldn't stand anymore.

MOTHER: "Charlayne, hey, come on. It's okay. *(She kisses her.)* It's okay. You

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don't have to go back. . . . No . . . Come on, let's get you out of these wet clothes. *(Mommy helps her out of her rain slicker, shakes the water off, and hangs it up on a hook.)* Take off those shoes and socks. I know your feet are soaked."

CHARLAYNE: Then my mother put on her own raincoat. She took back the dollar and the umbrella. And she left. I could hear Daddy puttering around in the basement, but I couldn't find Allie anywhere. And then I did. She was in her new hiding place, up under the dining room table, stretched out on the seats of the chairs. She was peeking out at me from underneath the lace tablecloth. And I could tell by the look in my sister's eyes . . . . that Allie already knew all too well . . . . what had happened to me.

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AWARD HISTORY

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